# The 15th Degree – Knight of the East, of the Sword or of the Eagle



“And behold, a throne was set in heaven, and one sat on the throne .... and there was a rainbow round about the throne, in sight like unto an emerald. And round about the throne were four and twenty elders sitting.” Revelation 4:2–4

The cordon of a Knight of the East is a broad, green watered ribbon, worn as a baldric, from left to right, without a jewel.

Also among the clothing of this degree is a broad sash of white watered silk edged on the upper side and fringed with gold on the lower. It is worn around the waist with the ends hanging down on the left side. It is embroidered with mutilated human body parts and on one end a gold arched bridge with the letters L.D.P. over the arch. Suspended from the right side is a small silver trowel.

The apron is crimson velvet. On the flap is an embroidered gold bleeding head over crossed swords. In the center are three nested gold triangles formed from chains with triangular links. These represent the chains on the human intellect: tyranny, superstition and privilege. The velvet signifies that the honors of Masonry are more precious than the gift of kings.

The jewel is three nested triangles of gold. In the center are two crossed swords, points upward, the hilts resting on the base of the inner triangle. The nested triangles symbolize liberty, equality and fraternity; and also law, order and subordination. The crossed swords, truth and justice.

There are additional decorations peculiar to this degree: green kid gloves and a black broad–brimmed hat with a green plume. Green, the dominant symbolic color, represents here the immortality of the human soul and even of Masonry itself. As you may recall in the Master Mason Degree of the Symbolic Lodge, Fellowcrafts present themselves before King Solomon clad in white gloves. White gloves are also worn in the 14th Degree of the Scottish Rite. In both instances, they are a symbol of innocence, cleanliness of mind, heart and soul.

DUTY

*Rebuild the Masonic temple of liberty, equality and fraternity in the souls of men and of nations.*

LESSONS

*Fidelity to trust, honor and duty.*

*Perseverance and constancy under difficulties and discouragements.*

FOR REFLECTION

*Is equality the basis of all freedom?*

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

*Bridge with letters L.D.P., the colors green, white and red, the trowel, and the sword.*

We have now reached the portal of a new allegory with an even more elaborate symbolism than previous degrees, for here we begin the Masonic

allegory of the Second Temple. The people of Israel, having followed Solomon into the worship of lesser gods, find themselves abandoned by the Lord. Taken as captives and slaves into Babylon, they serve a period of retribution longer even than their wanderings in the wilderness following their flight from Egypt under Moses which lasted 40 years. The Babylonian captivity lasted 70 years. This number is represented in the age of a Knight of the East– ten weeks of days, or 70 days. There comes into the small group of the people of Israel a type of the Perfect Elu, Zerubbabel, a Prince of Israel, who beseeches the Babylonian monarch, Cyrus, to free his people and allow them to rebuild the city and the House of the Lord.

The alternate names of this degree—Knight of the Sword and Knight of the Eagle—attest to its long and varied history and inclusion in the many Rites of Freemasonry. The title, Knight of the Sword, alludes to the legend that the Freemasons, in building the Second Temple, worked with the trowel in one hand and the sword in the other (Nehemiah 4:17–18). The other name, Knight of the Eagle, is based on the symbolic meaning of the eagle in this degree—liberty.

## CEREMONY

The set for enacting this degree is elaborate. There are three apartments and a passage between the first two with a bridge. The first apartment is called the Hall of the West and represents the encampment of the Hebrews in tents and huts amid the ruins of Jerusalem. The hangings of crimson, blue, purple and white are discussed in detail in the next degree. The altar is concealed behind a painted scene of the city of Jerusalem in ruins. Above the altar is a transparency of a blazing five–pointed star with rays of red and green. Green is emblematic here of the immortality of Masonry and of the hope that someday Masonic truth will be universal. Red should remind us that the honors of Masonry are more precious than the gifts of kings and, like the crimson of the morning, heralds a new day of hope. There are 70 candles in this apartment, seven in ten groups, each seven forming a triangle and a square. These lights also represent the 70 years of captivity. One in each group is lighted as the ritual begins.

The second apartment, called the Hall of the East, represents the Council Chamber of Cyrus, King of Persia, at Babylon. It is brilliantly lit, hung with green from floor to ceiling and contains a magnificent throne adorned with gold. A transparency behind the throne depicts the dream of Cyrus which incited him to free the Hebrew captives in Babylon and to contribute to rebuilding the Temple in Jerusalem. The scene on the transparency contains a roaring lion ready to spring, a blazing star (also called a brilliant glory), an eagle with a ribbon in his mouth bearing the words, “Restore Liberty to the Captives,” and two human figures, prostrate, eating grass who represent previous kings of Babylon.

The bridge between the two apartments contains the letters L.D.P. These letters have two meanings. The first and oldest from the French rituals describes the letters as standing for the phrase *Liberté de Passer* or “Liberty of Passage.” The second interpretation added by Pike is that the letters stand for the phrase *Liberté de Penser* or “Liberty of Thought.” Often the origin of a word is particularly interesting or enlightening. The word “liberty” in English can be traced back to the word *liber* in Latin meaning “bark,” on which books were originally written. Thus, *liber* also came to mean “book,” hence our word “library.” It is this original meaning, that helps us better understand the phrases “Tree of Knowledge” which may also be expressed “Book of Wisdom,” and “the Tree of Life” which is also expressed as “the Book of Life.” As related to this degree, liberty means liberty of thought, speech and action; and the freedom which knowledge confers. The word “passage” derives from the French pass which itself is derived from the Latin *passus* meaning “step.” The alternative interpretation of the letters L.D.P. is *Liberté de Penser; penser* derives from the Latin meaning “to weigh or consider.” Pike is suggesting the Knight of the East consider the important concept of liberty. Then combining the two meanings of L.D.P., we learn that with proper consideration the freedom which knowledge confers is attainable in steps or degrees.

The third apartment represents the treasure chamber of King Cyrus which contains the sacred treasures of the First Temple–the Ark of the Covenant,

golden candlesticks, the altar and the gold and silver vessels.

The drama begins in the first apartment, the Hall of the West; the candidate is received as Zerubbabel and the Master of Ceremonies answers for him. Zerubbabel, dressed as a Perfect Elu, is required to give the covered word of the 14th Degree. He comes from Babylon to inspect the ruins of the Temple. He is welcomed by the Hebrew people who describe themselves as distressed, poor and discouraged. Zerubbabel explains that he will return to Babylon to ask King Cyrus to follow through with his promises to help rebuild the Temple. He is confident because Cyrus is an initiate of the Mysteries of Mithra and thus is a Son of the Light and has the True Word. The brothers pray to the Lord to stir up the spirit of King Cyrus, for they realize it is the Lord only who can prosper their work.

Zerubbabel travels to Babylon and appears before Cyrus. His hands and neck are bound with three chains of triangular links. Cyrus recognizes him as the person who saved his life in battle and as an Adept in the Mysteries. The King agrees to grant Zerubbabel's request if he will tell him the secrets of the Order. Zerubbabel, of course, tells the King he will not forsake his honor and integrity; he would rather the Temple remain in ruins and he were killed or kept in the chains of slavery than betray the secrets. Zerubbabel is taken to the Treasure Chamber and shown the lost treasures of the Temple, an even greater temptation. He prays for strength, a voice from God reassures him, and he does not yield to temptation, saying, "I keep the Holy Fire." Zerubbabel's name in Hebrew is Sasbatzer, translated by Pike as "Keeper of the Fire." Zerubbabel reminds Cyrus of his own oath to Mithra. Cyrus yields and grants Zerubbabel his liberty, freeing him of the chains and providing a purple robe—a symbol of royalty—and for Zerubbabel, of the reward of virtue.

Zerubbabel appreciates his freedom but presses his request that the Jews be allowed to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the city and the Temple. Cyrus relates a dream to those assembled around him which is interpreted by the character in the ceremony who represents the prophet Daniel, a hint to us of where this particular dream may be found; that is, in the Bible in the Book of Daniel,

Chapter 4. The dream is interpreted as the fate which awaits Cyrus if he does not keep his promise to free the Hebrew captives, restore the holy vessels and aid in the rebuilding of the Temple—to be devoured by an angry lion. Cyrus rewards Zerubbabel's fidelity to honor by appointing him Governor of Judea. He also invests him with the collar of a Noble of Medea and Persia and gives him his signet ring as a symbol that Zerubbabel has Cyrus' authority to accomplish his mission.

Zerubbabel and the men charged to assure his safety in the journey west to Jerusalem encounter robbers at the bridge. During the ensuing conflict, Zerubbabel loses the collar given to him by Cyrus. Beneath the bridge is a representation of a river with bodies and human limbs and heads floating in it. The passage over the bridge should remind us of the long and arduous, but necessary, struggle for a people to pass from slavery to freedom, from degradation and ignorance to civilization and enlightenment, from spiritual bondage to spiritual liberty. It also should remind us that the life of virtue is not a life of ease but of constant struggle.

Upon his return to Jerusalem, Zerubbabel is saluted and honored by his brethren. Since the collar of Cyrus was lost, Zerubbabel creates this degree and instructs all that there are dignities in life to be valued much more than gifts from kings. The seventy candles are lit (emblems of the seventy years of captivity), the altar revealed and the candidate invested with the title Knight of the East, to emulate the character Zerubbabel.

As a Knight of the East, the candidate hears a lengthy oration on the symbolism and legend associated with the degree which contains a great deal of information on the history of the Hebrew people. The historical facts are elaborated to complete the allegory.

To the Mason, Zerubbabel is the type of leader who perseveres, encourages the disheartened, cheers the timid, incites the indolent, forces the apathetic and reluctant and has incorruptible fidelity to honor and duty.

The construction of the Second Temple is begun in this degree, but not finished. Its reconstruction symbolizes the restitution of the primitive truth to

men. It also stands for national and well–regulated liberty and the state of peace and toleration that will make the earth a fit place to dwell.

## LECTURE

Although the lecture in *Morals and Dogma* is short, only four pages, it enlightens us further on the teachings presented in the ritual. It provides us with hints of the lessons of future degrees, as related particularly to the nature of Deity. To rebuild the Masonic Temple of liberty, equality and fraternity in the souls of men and nations is the duty of every Knight of the East and the great crusade of Masonry. To accomplish this goal, the true Mason must be possessed of fidelity, constancy and perseverance.

**To Rebuild the Symbolic Temple with Fidelity:**

*The chief obstacles to* [Masonry's] *success are the apathy and faithlessness of her own selfish children, and the supine indifference of the world. In the roar and crush and hurry of life and business, and the tumult and uproar of politics, the quiet voice of Masonry is unheard and unheeded* (p. 237).

*It is the motionless and stationary that most frets and impedes the current of progress... : the Masons that doubt and hesitate and are discouraged; that disbelieve in the capability of man to improve; that are not disposed to toil and labor for the interest and well–being of general humanity; that expect others to do all, even of that which they do not oppose or ridicule; while they sit, applauding and doing nothing, ...* (p. 238).

*...one of those laws, uttered by God's voice, and speaking through every nerve and fibre, every force and element, of the moral constitution He has given us, is that we must be upright and virtuous; that if tempted we must resist; that we must govern our unruly passions, and hold in hand our sensual appetites. And this is not the dictate of an arbitrary will, nor of some stern and impracticable law; but it is part of the great firm law of harmony that binds the Universe together: not the mere enactment of arbitrary will; but the dictate of Infinite Wisdom* (pp. 239–240).

**To Rebuild the Symbolic Temple with Perseverance and Constancy:**

*Masonry is engaged in her crusade,—against ignorance, intolerance, fanaticism, superstition, uncharitableness, and error. She does not sail with the trade–winds, upon a smooth sea, with a steady free breeze, fair for a welcoming harbor; but meets and must overcome many opposing currents, baffling winds, and dead calms* (p. 237).

*...let us remember that the only question for us to ask, as true men and Masons, is, what does duty require; and not what will be the result of our reward if we do our duty. Work on, with the Sword in one hand, and the Trowel in the other!* (p. 239).